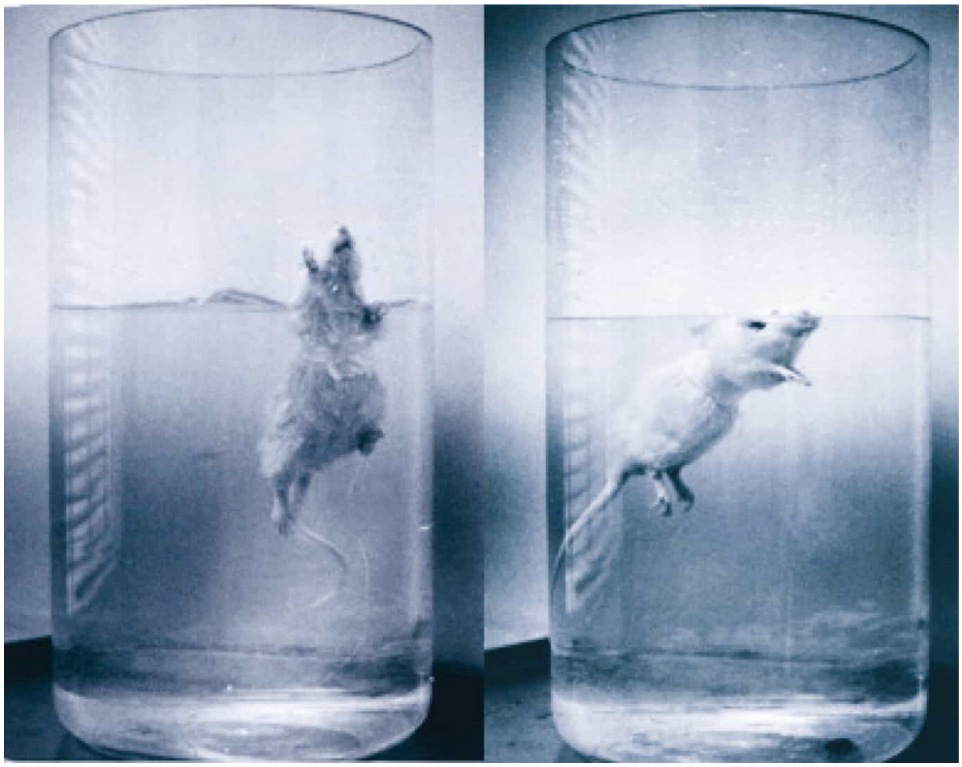


Credit 1.16

16. Left: A hopeful rat struggling to escape the glass tube. Right: An apathetic rat floating in the glass tube, having lost all hope.

Sceptics could object that this entire description needlessly humanises rats. Rats experience neither hope nor despair. Sometimes rats move quickly and sometimes they stand still, but they never feel anything. They are driven only by non-conscious algorithms. Yet if so, what's the point of all these experiments? Psychiatric drugs are aimed to induce changes not just in human behaviour, but above all in human *feeling*. When customers go to a psychiatrist and say, 'Doctor, give me something that will lift me out of this depression,' they don't want a mechanical stimulant that will cause them to flail about while still feeling blue. They want to *feel* cheerful. Conducting experiments on rats can help corporations develop such a magic pill only if they presuppose that rat behaviour is accompanied by human-like emotions. And indeed, this is a common presupposition in psychiatric laboratories.[10]

The Self-Conscious Chimpanzee